Control vs. Capability Diagnostic

Purpose

Examine whether a process can reliably produce the required outcome—or whether controls are compensating for weaknesses in the process itself.

What It Is

A structured way to distinguish process capability from the controls used to prevent, detect, or manage failure.

What It Is Not

An argument against controls, a control-risk assessment, a statistical capability analysis, or a reason to remove required safeguards.

Diagnostic Lens

A. Start With the Required Outcome

Before evaluating the controls, establish what the process must reliably produce and what happens when it does not.

What must this process reliably produce?

Describe the result, condition, output, or performance the process is expected to achieve. **What would tell us the process is capable of doing that consistently?**

What are we relying on to keep the outcome acceptable?

Identify the controls surrounding the process and what each one is expected to accomplish. **Which of these controls are required—and which exist because the process cannot otherwise be trusted?**

01 Outcome

What must the process reliably produce?

Define acceptable performance before evaluating how the process is controlled.

02 Method

How does the process create that outcome?

Identify the work, decisions, conditions, inputs, equipment, information, or behaviors necessary to produce the result.

03 Variation

Where does meaningful variation enter the process?

Look for differences in inputs, methods, people, technology, timing, environment, workload, or operating conditions.

04 Failure

How does the process fail to produce the required outcome?

Describe what actually goes wrong, not merely where the failure is eventually detected.

05 Prevention

What makes failure less likely to occur?

Identify controls that change the process or conditions before failure happens.

06 Detection

What tells us that failure occurred or may have occurred?

Consider inspection, review, verification, monitoring, reconciliation, testing, alarms, and other detection mechanisms.

07 Intervention

What happens after the control identifies a problem?

Determine who acts, what they do, and whether the intervention corrects the process or only the immediate output.

08 Dependency

What happens if this control disappears tomorrow?

Consider whether the process remains capable, becomes less reliable, or can no longer be trusted to produce the required outcome.

Observations / Evidence

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B. Test the Dependency

A control can reduce risk without improving the underlying process. Determine what the control actually contributes and why the system depends on it.

Control	Function	Reason	Without It
What control are we examining?	**What does it prevent, detect, correct, or contain?**	**Why is the control necessary?**	**What would happen if the control were removed?**

Decision Frame

Is the Process Capable Without This Control?

Establish whether the process can reliably produce the required outcome without depending on the control.

Yes	Question	No
The process remains capable without the control.	Does the control still address a legitimate requirement or residual risk?	The process depends on the control to achieve or verify acceptable performance.
Retain	**Build In**	**Reduce Dependency**
Keep the control where it addresses a legitimate requirement or residual risk.	Redesign the process so prevention or control becomes inherent to how the work is performed.	Improve process capability so the control carries less of the burden for acceptable performance.

C. Define the Operating State

Make the relationship between capability and control explicit. Preserve controls that manage real risk without allowing them to hide weaknesses in the process.

Capability	Variation
What can the process reliably do on its own?	**What meaningful variation or failure remains?**
Control	**Evidence**
What still requires prevention, detection, or intervention?	**How will we know the process and controls continue to work as intended?**

If This Control Disappeared Tomorrow, What Would That Reveal About the Process?

Open Lab Note: Controls are part of many well-designed systems. The question is not whether controls exist. The question is what the system depends on them to do. A control may manage legitimate residual risk—or it may compensate for a process that cannot reliably produce the required outcome. Understanding that distinction changes where improvement effort belongs.

Use it. Challenge it. Change it. Make it better. Share what you learned.

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